THE BOOK AND ITS REVIEWERS

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Appointment in Crete was published by Allan Wingate of 12 Beauchamp Place, London, on 16 July 1953, at fifteen shillings, in a dust jacket designed by the author's friend the painter John Craxton. It was reviewed in The Times on 22 July and in the Times Literary Supplement two days later, and noticed in a dozen other papers and journals that summer and autumn. The pages that follow gather those reviews that could be recovered, the publisher's own description of the book, and a note of the historians who have drawn on it since. They are not part of the original book.

THE SPHERE
15 August 1953

The World of Books

Appointment in Crete (Wingate. 15s.) is the story of a British agent, with a difference, and that lies in the fact that its author, Mr. A. M. Rendel, found himself leading this life of highly-coloured adventure almost by chance. Classical scholar turned solicitor turned soldier, in 1943 he was in Cairo, dining with another English officer, an old friend, who suggested that he might be suitable for a more irregular kind of job—organising the fifth column against the Germans in Crete. Mr. Rendel accepted and, so far as one can gather from his lively narrative, took to it like a

duck to water, relishing everything from his hastily-grown brigand's moustache to gun-running, sabotage, the landing of agents by sea and air and general extra-curricular activities. His modern Greek was little and his training for a life on the run even less, but, with many of his companions, he survived to tell the story of another British victory and of Greek friendship.
Vernon Fane

THE SPECTATOR
25 September 1953

Cretan Labyrinth

"No. There isn't much chance of washing and you don't feel much inclined in this cold weather. They never do." "They," of course, are the Cretans. And if you disregard an unfortunate book-cover, Appointment in Crete plunges at once into an atmosphere conspiratorial yet typically British. For this is a very British book; highly individual, moving and permeated with that "amateur" spirit whose enthusiasm and initiative have seldom failed to make the stories of our "side-shows" the most popular accounts of the last two wars. If one should occasionally wonder whether so much hardship and risk achieved much beyond showing the British flag, that is certainly not the fault of the author, whose endearing personality emerges early in the book and sustains us for some fifty pages until he is hidden away in the mountains overlooking the plain of Heraklion. Besides a fine blend of modesty and courage, Major Rendel's qualifications for a very hazardous year in Crete were an ability to read ancient Greek and a somewhat hazy memory of a five-week walking tour twelve years earlier on the Greek mainland.

Is it any wonder that, at first, his mission was not blessed with success? Whilst landing, he loses overboard, not only the cunningly camouflaged charging engine for his wireless but his precious suitcase containing propaganda leaflets, maps, identity cards and an invaluable Greek dictionary. But a voice is hailing from the shore. Rendel lands, an outgoing Italian General takes his place in the boat and the new British agent is in the midst of a boisterous Cretan welcome—soon to dissolve into angry bickering. And thus—in the autumn of 1943—Rendel's Cretan Appointment begins; a period of heart-breaking initiation when, out of touch with Cairo, a long series of misfortunes and disappointments only serve to bring out his better qualities. And soon the tide is turning. He builds up a private band of Cretans clad in black sarikis, shepherd's breeches and jackboots soled with strips from motor tyres, who are to be his faithful companions. Soon he is organising an intelligence network, making long and difficult marches through the country and vainly endeavouring to rally the diverse elements of Cretan resistance. This is a well-told story of a hard, adventurous year, which never fails to hold the attention; air-drops, demolitions, coping with Rosebud and Clubfoot the Communist leaders, hide-and-seek with the German patrols and a penetration into German-occupied Heraklion where he sets up his wireless next door to German wireless headquarters. It is exciting and genuine. But it is more than that. Rendel has caught the atmosphere of the Island; the mountains, the little villages, the plain shimmering with heat. He has caught, too, in a dozen little portraits, its remarkable people; the members of his band, the guides and shepherds, the hospitable, but dangerously loquacious villagers, the Archimandrite of the monastery where Rendel hides beneath the floor boards from a German patrol. Nor at the

moment of triumph, amidst the flowers and shouting and the bottle of champagne does he forget the burnt-out villages and the white crosses which are the burden of those who organise a resistance movement. Whether taking tea in a house beneath the noses of the Germans or encountering villagers picking snails after rain, Rendel is always conscious of his friends—the Cretans; brave beyond discretion, brimming with tragi-comic heroism, vital with a resilience which has survived both Turk and German. Appointment in Crete is a book that will not be easily forgotten. It is too genuine, too sincere; constantly illuminated with little flashes that tell their own revealing story. "Well, Mr. Alexis," says Friar Tuck, the Orthodox priest with parachute wings, placing a chair amidst the ruins of his house, "I always said that one day I would welcome you to my home. As you see there's not much left of it but at least we can offer you a glass."
James Kinross

THE NEW STATESMAN AND NATION
26 September 1953

Scenes of Military Life

War digs its roots deep and spreads its branches wide. For fifteen years past all of us, whether dons, mechanics, bricklayers or accountants, have been sucked out of our native soil and scattered in every unlikely corner of the world. . . . This is the situation which both Mr. Rendel and Major Campbell describe in their books: the scattering of Englishmen to the mountains of Crete or the jungles of Malaya and their painful and successful adaptation to hardships for which nothing in their lives has prepared them. . . . Appointment in Crete, an account of Mr. Rendel's life as a British agent during the war, is a good

work in the tradition made familiar by Julian Amery and Fitzroy Maclean in the recent war, by T. E. Lawrence in the last. Byron is the patron saint of these versatile, independent spirits for whom regimental life is merely an extension of the ennui of peace.

Mr. Rendel describes his life as an outlaw simply and objectively, without dramatic distortion. He makes very clear a point which books of this type tend to obscure—that the work of the British was merely ancillary to a sturdy native movement of independence in which we were accepted as bona fide allies; and he writes with charity both of the Germans and—what is even rarer—of his superiors in Cairo. The British Army uses its irregulars as intelligently as the Roman Church, which allows its fanatics to found new preaching orders. We are shown how this cloak-and-dagger work fitted in to the general activity of the Middle East; how it was provided with supplies—dehydrated carrots, Army pants, mines disguised as camel-dung—and how it passed its information. We are lucky that Mr. Rendel survived to write this agreeable and impressive book; a tendency to confuse cyanide pills with raisins made it a near thing.

A joint review with Arthur Campbell's Jungle Green; the passages about Appointment in Crete are given. Unsigned.

BRITISH BOOK NEWS
October 1953

The more spectacular exploits of British officers in Crete during the occupation have already been very well publicised. This is the first account of the equally dangerous but more solid work of the underground, the routine collection of intelligence, the planning and execution of sabotage, and the unrelenting toil and self-sacrifice of officers, agents and civilians which kept

resistance groups in the field for years on end. The author spent eighteen months in Eastern Crete. His exciting story pays a long-deserved tribute to the pioneers such as Dunbabin and Leigh-Fermor, and shows a sensible understanding as well as deep admiration for the Cretans.
The British Council's monthly guide to new books. Unsigned.

THE ANNUAL REGISTER
1953

. . . for connoisseurs of Resistance literature was A. M. Rendel's Appointment in Crete (Wingate). Although a personal account, it had the merit of putting earlier best-sellers into perspective . . .
From the survey of the year's literature; only the opening of the notice could be recovered.

WORLD AFFAIRS (WASHINGTON)
July 1954

Another cloak and dagger memoir—this time by a British agent in occupied Crete during the war.
From the "Recent Books" column; the same line appeared in Foreign Affairs.

THE PUBLISHER'S DESCRIPTION, FROM THE JACKET

This is a personal account of the adventures, thoughts and feelings of an ordinary citizen who found himself suddenly, and more or less by chance, a British agent in Crete. There, in the mountains for over a year, he lived, in his own words, a life "real to the point of intensity and romantic to the point of melodrama."

From the rather humdrum existence of a classical

scholar turned solicitor, Rendel found himself, as a result of a chance encounter in a Cairo restaurant, transformed almost overnight into a moustachioed conspirator, dressed as a Greek peasant, living in shepherds' caves or hidden in monastery cellars, and finally running a secret wireless inside Herakleion. He became a desperado seasoned in gun-running and the landing of agents by air and sea, in the direction of an intelligence net, in clandestine meetings between rival outlaws in the hills, and in fifth-column work such as the burning of petrol dumps and other sorts of sabotage against the occupation forces. He was often on the run from German patrols in the mountains and on the open plain, and he describes with fidelity and humour his vagabond life among the villagers with whom, at first, he could only share a few broken words of modern Greek, yet who fed him, hid him, guided him and, in many cases, became his lifelong friends.

Appointment in Crete is a completely authentic, full-blooded and, at the same time, sensitive and almost poetic account of high adventure, very much in the tradition of *Dare To Be* Free. Once again we find a young Britisher who, through his . . . [the remainder of the blurb, on the back flap, is still to be recovered from an original jacket].

ABOUT THE AUTHOR, FROM THE JACKET

A. M. Rendel was born in London in 1910 and was educated at Rugby and Corpus Christi College, Oxford. After leaving the University, he worked as a freelance journalist in the Saar and Geneva, travelled widely in Europe, including Greece, and then worked for four years in a solicitor's office in the City.

He had just married when the outbreak of war took him to an artillery O.C.T.U. in November, 1939. His first three

years of soldiering were spent uneventfully in the United Kingdom, Persia and Iraq, and it was a chance encounter that brought him suddenly into the midst of the resistance movement in Crete, where his adventures form the subject of this book.

He returned to Greece with his family after the war, and worked for three years in the British Embassy in Athens. He now lives in London with his wife and five children.

Reviews also appeared in The Times (22 July 1953, page 11) and in the Times Literary Supplement (page 471, 24 July 1953). Their texts are held in the newspapers' digital archives, which most public libraries can reach, and would be a welcome addition to this appendix.

THE BOOK IN LATER HISTORIES

Patrick Leigh Fermor, in his introduction and notes to George Psychoundakis's The Cretan Runner (1955), calls Appointment in Crete "an excellent account" and identifies its author as "Sandy Rendel—Alexis—who works on The Times". In Abducting a General (2014) he recalls "I stayed with Sandy Rendel in his cave for over a month . . . in the Lasithi mountains" before the kidnapping of General Kreipe.

W. Stanley Moss, Ill Met by Moonlight (1950), describes Rendel as "the Times correspondent, the polished and educated" officer who met the kidnap party; the 1957 film gave the part of Captain Sandy Rendel to Cyril Cusack.

Dilys Powell, The Villa Ariadne (1973), and Adam Hopkins, Crete: Its Past, Present and People (1977), draw on the book; Hopkins calls it "a good companion" to Xan Fielding's Hide and Seek and retells Rendel's peace-making feast between rival bands.

Antony Beevor, Crete: The Battle and the Resistance (1991), quotes Rendel on the Cairo farewell that "seemed all too like a third-rate thriller and therefore faintly bogus", on the cyanide pills he carried in his jacket pocket, and on his arrival in Lasithi.

Artemis Cooper, Patrick Leigh Fermor: An Adventure (2012); Wes Davis, The Ariadne Objective (2013), which prints photographs from the Rendel family archive; and Rick Stroud, Kidnap in Crete (2014), which opens a chapter with Rendel in his cave on 5 February 1944 and uses his letters in the Imperial War Museum.

An extract, "A First Parachute Jump", was anthologised in school readers from the 1960s to the 1990s (A Mirror of the Times, 1964; Speech for Life, 1966; Thoughtweavers, 1979; Tradewinds, 1990).

The Times, 21 November 1991: the obituary of Alexander "Sandy" Meadows Rendel, C.B.E., its diplomatic correspondent from 1952 to 1975, who died on 14 November aged 81. It recalls the chance meeting in wartime Cairo, "two years in mountain caves, dressed as a shepherd", messages written in ancient Greek capitals, the pre-war solicitor's office and the Saar plebiscite of 1935, the United Nations and the British Embassy in Athens after the war, the interview with Tito, and "a journalist of the old school . . . full of old-fashioned integrity and charm". He was survived by his wife Elizabeth and five children.